

TOPOS-SRE

USER MANUAL

How to drive the weird little semantic machine without needing a degree in cybernetic occultism.

SRE-V3 / LOCAL-FIRST BUILD

Basic controls, experiments, diagnostics, perturbations, and token-safety notes.

<https://topossre.netlify.app>

github.com/merrypranxter/topos_sre

THE ONE SENTENCE VERSION

Give TOPOS-SRE a starting thought. The controller measures each result, changes the rules, and feeds the altered state back through the loop. You watch what happens.

01 Quick Start

If you read nothing else, read this page.

MONEY / TOKEN SAFETY

The normal controls in the current build run locally in your browser/app logic. Ignite, Step once, Run x4, Variation, and all perturbations do NOT call a paid model API. The UI should show: LOCAL - \$0 API - NO TOKEN BURN.

Your first experiment

1. Type a boring starting thought: hand holds cup
2. Click Ignite experiment.
3. Click Step once four or five times. Read only the output cards at first.
4. Try Run x4. Watch how four connected cycles drift without you touching anything.
5. Move Variation from about 0.90 toward 1.20-1.35 and run another few cycles.
6. When the output starts feeling repetitive, open Kick it sideways and apply Semantic bomb.
7. Only after something interesting happens, open Controller guts and inspect why.

WHY START BORING?

A plain seed gives the machine less stylistic material to imitate. If hand holds cup turns into something strange, the weirdness is more likely coming from the loop dynamics instead of being smuggled in by your prompt.

The mental model

CONTROLLER	GENERATOR	LOOP
Measures	Executes	Feeds back
chooses rules	makes the next text	result becomes new input

Important: TOPOS-SRE is not trying to write "good prose" or "weird prose." It is trying to satisfy changing constraints. Style is an outcome, not the target.

02 What Everything Means

The dashboard in normal-human language.

CONTROL / AREA	WHAT IT ACTUALLY DOES
Starting thought	The seed you throw into the machine. A word, sentence, question, or phrase.
Ignite experiment	Creates the initial controller state. It does not run a full experiment by itself.
Step once	Runs exactly one controller -> generator -> controller cycle. Best for learning what the machine is doing.
Run x4	Runs four connected cycles automatically. Good for watching trajectories instead of individual moves.
Stop burst	Stops the remaining automatic cycles.
Variation	Controls how aggressively the LOCAL executor mixes its allowed token inventory. This is not a paid-model temperature control in the current build.
What the creature said	The main output. Each card is one completed cycle.
What rules are active?	The controller summary. It tells you what the machine is measuring and what it plans to do next.
Kick it sideways	Perturbations: deliberate state shocks you apply before the next cycle.
Controller guts	Advanced diagnostics: similarity meters, symbols, the exact OP_BLOCK, and audit trail.
External model bridge	Advanced manual input. TOPOS does not send anything anywhere; you paste output from some outside generator yourself.

IGNORE THIS AT FIRST

You do not need to understand the OP_BLOCK, symbol table, SIM_STRUCT, SIM_SEMANTIC, or audit trail to play. Those are forensic tools for after the machine does something worth investigating.

03 Reading a Run

What to watch while the creature mutates.

Every output card gives you four useful clues

- C001, C002, C003... = cycle number. This is your timeline.
- Structure = the current structural matrix: the shape the output must fit.
- Operation = the mutation being applied this cycle: tense shift, agency swap, direction reversal, domain pivot, symbol leap, etc.
- Decay = how far ordinary language has been eroded, from 1/10 to 10/10.

The four controller stats

STAT	PLAIN ENGLISH	WHAT TO NOTICE
Cycle	How many passes have completed.	Useful when comparing runs or locating the moment something changed.
Decay	How much normal language capability has been stripped away.	Higher decay can push the system toward fragments, short tokens, verbs, or symbols.
Tension	How hard the controller is escalating incompatible constraints.	When tension rises, expect more drastic controller behavior.
Attractor	How long the recent output has stayed suspiciously similar.	A growing streak means the loop may be getting stuck in a stable groove.

Interesting does NOT necessarily mean "more surreal"

The most useful events are changes in behavior: a repeated structure suddenly breaks, a symbol starts carrying a role, an ordinary sentence collapses into shorthand, a mutation unexpectedly stabilizes the loop, or the system escapes one pattern and falls into another. The experiment is about dynamics, not a weirdness contest.

GOOD HABIT

When something makes you say "what the fuck was THAT," write down the cycle number before touching anything. Then open Controller guts and inspect the exact operation, similarities, event, and OP_BLOCK around that cycle.

04 How to Push It

Variation and perturbations are different tools.

Variation

Variation changes how aggressively the local executor mixes material that the controller has already allowed. It does not rewrite the controller rules. Think of it as how loosely the executor rummages through the legal parts bin.

RANGE	ROUGH FEEL
0.20-0.54	tight
0.55-0.89	restrained
0.90-1.14	loose
1.15-1.40	unruly

Perturbations: deliberate shocks to controller state

Semantic bomb

Rotate into the opposing relation inventory.

WHY TRY IT: Use when vocabulary or meaning is getting too comfortable. Watch whether the path changes while the rest of the machine state remains continuous.

Structural glitch

Force a different structural matrix for one turn.

WHY TRY IT: Use when the form is repetitive but the vocabulary is still alive. Good for testing whether structure or content is holding the attractor together.

Rewrite the seed

Replace the original anchor while preserving current machine state.

WHY TRY IT: This is a seed transplant. Excellent for asking: does the mature controller state dominate the new idea, or does the new idea reorganize the state?

Recursive echo

Throw cycle 1 back into the loop as input.

WHY TRY IT: Tests memory and recurrence. Useful after a long drift to see how the original transformed material behaves inside the later machine.

Scarecrow

Apply NULL_ADMIN, a deliberate controller dead-zone.

WHY TRY IT: Useful as a control condition. It temporarily removes mutation pressure so you can see what the current structure does with less intervention.

05 Experiment Cookbook

Things to try, what to watch, and why.

A. The boring-seed baseline

DO: Seed: hand holds cup | Variation: 0.90 | Step 8-12 times

WATCH: Watch when the vocabulary first leaves the literal scene.

WHY: This gives you a relatively clean view of controller-caused drift.

B. Same seed, different executor freedom

DO: Repeat the same seed at Variation 0.35, 0.90, and 1.30.

WATCH: Compare speed of drift, repetition, and attractor duration.

WHY: Separates executor freedom from controller logic.

C. Hunt an attractor

DO: Use Run x4 repeatedly without perturbing until Attractor rises.

WATCH: Look for repeated shapes, repeated inventories, or near-cloned sentences.

WHY: Lets the machine show you where it naturally gets stuck before you intervene.

D. Break the attractor two ways

DO: At the same kind of stuck state, try Semantic bomb in one run and Structural glitch in another.

WATCH: Which one actually escapes? Does meaning or form snap back first?

WHY: Tests what is holding the attractor together.

E. Seed transplant

DO: Run 12-20 cycles, then Rewrite the seed to something unrelated: velvet, tax return, moth wing, Tuesday.

WATCH: Does the mature controller digest the new seed into its old world, or reorganize?

WHY: Tests state persistence versus new semantic input.

F. Recursive archaeology

DO: After a long drift, use Recursive echo.

WATCH: Look for recognition, recurrence, mutation, or collision between early and late state.

WHY: Makes the loop confront its own fossil record.

G. Let decay happen

DO: Keep stepping/running long enough to watch Decay climb. Avoid perturbing unless it totally stalls.

WATCH: Track the transition from ordinary language toward shorter forms or symbols; watch for REBIRTH.

WHY: This is closest to the original SRE objective: forcing representation change through constraint pressure.

06 Controller Guts

Open this when you want to investigate, not merely play.

SIM_STRUCT

Structural similarity across recent outputs. Higher values mean recent outputs are shaped more alike. If this is high while semantic similarity is lower, the loop may be repeating form while changing content.

SIM_SEMANTIC

Token/inventory similarity across recent outputs. Higher values mean the same semantic material is being reused. When both structural and semantic similarity stay very high, the controller may treat the loop as an attractor.

Symbol table

Tracks glyphs that have entered the system and the roles/inheritance attached to them. Symbols matter because the system can eventually use them as compressed structure when ordinary words become harder to keep legal.

SRE_OP_BLOCK

The exact instruction packet the generator will execute next. This is the best forensic artifact in the app. If a cycle surprises you, inspect the OP_BLOCK from around that moment to see the relation set, structural constraint, operator, mappings, symbol stage, decay constraint, and input state.

Audit trail

A chronological record of controller events and rule passes. Use it to locate failures, attractor ticks, regime changes, and whether the hard structural rule was satisfied.

A USEFUL FORENSIC QUESTION

Instead of asking "why did it say that word?" ask: "What constraint, operator, relation inventory, and prior state made that output legal or likely at this cycle?" That question fits what TOPOS-SRE is actually doing.

07 Costs, Saving, and Not Breaking Shit

The boring part that prevents future swearing.

What costs model tokens in the current build?

NORMAL TOPOS CONTROLS: \$0 MODEL API

Ignite experiment, Step once, Run x4, Stop burst, Variation, Semantic bomb, Structural glitch, Rewrite the seed, Recursive echo, Scarecrow, opening Controller guts, copying the OP_BLOCK, and exporting a session are all local operations in the current build.

The External model bridge is only a paste box. TOPOS-SRE itself does not send that text to an API. However, if YOU use another AI elsewhere to create the text you paste into that box, that outside service may charge credits or tokens according to its own rules.

If the code is changed later to re-enable a remote model caller, treat that as a different operating mode. The current manual describes the local-first build dated September 16, 2026.

Saving an interesting run

- Use the export/download control in the header when you hit something worth keeping.
- The output panel only shows the newest chunk of cycles for readability; the exported session retains the fuller tape/controller state.
- Write down cycle numbers when something strange happens. They are your coordinates for later analysis.

If the app seems stuck

- First try Step once. A burst may simply have ended.
- If output is repetitive, inspect Attractor. Then try Semantic bomb or Structural glitch.
- If the experiment has become uninformative, export it before Reset so you can compare later.
- If the page behaves strangely after a new deploy, reload once. The app persists session state locally, so an old state can survive a UI update.

If you want a clean comparison

- Reset between experimental conditions.
- Keep the same seed and change only ONE thing: Variation, perturbation type, or intervention timing.
- Record the cycle at which you intervene. Otherwise you are comparing two completely different histories.

08 What Counts as a Good Result?

Not "did it make pretty nonsense?"

TOPOS-SRE is most interesting when its behavior reveals the consequences of the controller rules. A run can be valuable even if the text is ugly, repetitive, sparse, or broken.

PHENOMENON	WHY IT MATTERS
Regime shift	The output suddenly behaves like a different representational system instead of merely producing different words.
Attractor formation	The loop settles into a stable recurring pattern without being directly told to repeat.
Attractor escape	A rule, failure event, or perturbation genuinely pushes it into a different basin instead of producing a cosmetic one-cycle glitch.
Symbolic compression	Glyphs or shorthand begin carrying recurring structural/semantic roles as ordinary language erodes.
Unexpected resilience	The system finds a way to satisfy constraints you expected to break it.
Unexpected failure	A supposedly strong mechanism collapses, loops, or becomes trivial. Failures teach you which parts of the architecture are actually load-bearing.

THE GUIDING RULE
Do not tell the generator to "be weirder." Change measurable conditions and watch what weirdness, order, collapse, or invention emerges from them. That is the experiment.

A simple lab-note template

SEED:
VARIATION:
INTERVENTION + CYCLE:
WHAT CHANGED:
ATTRACTOR / DECAY / TENSION:
WEIRD MOMENT + CYCLE:
WHAT I THINK CAUSED IT:
WHAT TO TRY NEXT:

09 One-Page Cheat Sheet

For when you forget everything except "push button, make goblin."

START

Use a plain seed -> Ignite -> Step once 4-6 times -> Run x4 -> only then start changing things.

Controls

Step once: One cycle. Best for understanding causality.

Run x4: Four-cycle trajectory. Best for watching drift.

Variation: Executor looseness: 0.2 tight -> 1.4 unruly.

Semantic bomb: Change semantic neighborhood.

Structural glitch: Change form for a turn.

Rewrite seed: Swap the anchor, keep the mature state.

Recursive echo: Throw cycle 1 into the current loop.

Scarecrow: Temporary mutation dead-zone / control condition.

Controller guts: Forensics after something interesting happens.

Watch for

- Attractor climbing: the machine is getting stuck.
- Decay climbing: ordinary language is being stripped away.
- Tension climbing: constraints are escalating.
- Symbols recurring with roles: shorthand may be emerging.
- Sudden event/operator changes: possible regime shift or escape attempt.

Do not panic about credits

If the interface says LOCAL - \$0 API - NO TOKEN BURN, the normal loop is not using a paid model API. The external bridge is manual only.

BEST FIRST WEIRD EXPERIMENT

Run hand holds cup until an attractor starts forming. Export. Reset. Repeat the same seed, but this time hit Semantic bomb at the same approximate cycle. Compare the two trajectories. That is already a real little experiment.

Manual version: 1.0 | Based on the TOPOS-SRE local-first main branch and Netlify deployment as of September 16, 2026.